

tansy grows in open areas, alongside roads, and close to water. The flowering tops are collected as the flowers open in summer.

Parts Used Flowering tops.

Constituents Tansy contains a volatile oil, which includes significant levels of thujone and camphor; sesquiterpene lactones, flavonoids, and resin. The volatile oil strongly induces menstruation.

History & Folklore While it is not mentioned in surviving classical texts, tansy was described by medieval herbalists, notably St. Hildegard of Bingen (12th century). Ever since that time, tansy has been used most commonly as a worm-expelling plant. In England, tansy puddings were consumed during Lent.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Tansy is little used today because of its potential toxicity. When the plant is taken, it is chiefly in order to expel intestinal worms, and, to a lesser degree, to help stimulate menstrual bleeding. Tansy may be used externally to kill scabies, fleas, and lice, but even external application of tansy preparations carries the risk of toxicity.

⚠ Cautions Use only under professional supervision. Tansy is possibly unsafe for internal and external use, and should never be taken during pregnancy. The plant, and especially its essential oil, are subject to legal restrictions in some countries.



Tansy is a strong deworming remedy for use only under professional guidance.

Taxus baccata (Taxaceae)

Yew

Description Slow-growing evergreen tree reaching 80 ft (25 m) in height. Has rust-red bark and flattened, dark green needle-like leaves. The female trees produce fleshy red cup-like fruit.



Yew, no longer used in herbal medicine, is currently under research as a potential anticancer drug.

Habitat & Cultivation Yew grows throughout northern temperate zones. More often found in cultivation than in the wild, it prefers lime-rich soil. The leaves are gathered in spring.

Parts Used Leaves.

Constituents Yew contains a mixture of alkaloids known as taxine, and also diterpenes (including taxol in some varieties), lignans, tannin, and resin.

History & Folklore The yew tree was sacred to the Druids, who are believed to have considered it an emblem of immortality. The Druids planted yews in holy sites, a practice that continued with the coming of Christianity. Many medieval churchyards contain ancient yews, some thought to be over 2,000 years old. In the Middle Ages, the best longbows were made from yew wood, as were magic wands.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Though yew has been used in small doses to treat rheumatic and urinary problems, its extreme toxicity makes it an unsafe medicinal plant.

Research Taxol inhibits cell division, and has thus been extensively researched for its use as an anti-cancer drug. Taxol is most commonly found in the Pacific yew (*T. brevifolia*), though some varieties of

T. baccata also contain the substance. Studies have been conducted since the 1980s in search of potential cancer treatments.

⚠ Caution Yew is extremely toxic. Do not take under any circumstances.

Terminalia belerica (Combretaceae)

Beleric Myrobalan

Description Evergreen tree with clusters of oval leaves, spikes of small greenish unpleasant-smelling flowers, and hairy brown fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Beleric myrobalan is native to India, Malaysia, and the Philippines. It is found in forests and is cultivated for its astringent fruit, which is gathered both immature and ripe.

Part Used Fruit.

Constituents The fruit contains tannins and anthraquinones.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Beleric myrobalan fruit is astringent, tonic, and laxative. It is principally employed as a treatment for digestive and respiratory problems. In Indian herbal medicine, the ripe fruit is taken for diarrhea and indigestion, and the unripe fruit is used as a laxative for chronic constipation. It forms part of the classic Ayurvedic Triphala formula, chiefly used as a bowel tonic. Beleric myrobalan is also often used to treat upper respiratory tract infections that cause symptoms of sore throats, hoarseness, and coughs.

Related Species Many *Terminalia* species are used to make astringent remedies, and also for their timber. See chebolic myrobalan (*T. chebula*, following entry).

Caution Do not take during pregnancy.

Terminalia chebula (Combretaceae)

Chebolic Myrobalan

Description Evergreen tree growing to 65 ft (20 m). Has egg-shaped leaves, white flowers in terminal spikes, and small, 5-ribbed fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Central Asia and India, chebolic myrobalan is found throughout Iran, Pakistan, and India. The fruit is collected when ripe.

Part Used Fruit.

Constituents Chebolic myrobalan contains triterpenes, polyphenols, a coumarin (chebolic acid), resin, and fixed oil.

History & Folklore Chebolic myrobalan has been used in Indian medicine for several thousand years, and the fruit has long been considered a prime remedy for all manner of digestive problems.